490.LIFE · THE WHOLE STORY · LESSON 4 OF 26

The Fall

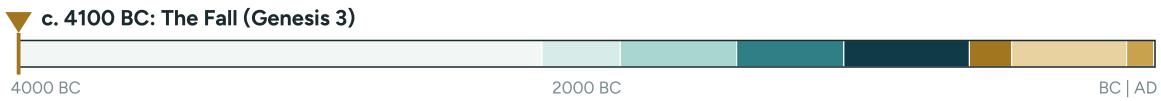
Genesis 3 · Romans 5:12–21



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YOU ARE HERE · LESSON 4



Introduction: Why Does the World Feel So Wrong?

Last week we stood in a garden where everything was very good. A river ran through it, the trees were heavy with fruit, a man and a woman worked and rested with nothing to hide, and God came near. Now look up from the page at the world you actually live in. Hospitals. Funerals. Divorce papers. The news. The way you snapped at someone you love this morning. The thing you swore you would never do again and did.

Everyone knows the world is not the way it should be. We feel it in our bones. The question is why. Some say suffering is just nature, the way things have always been. Some say the problem is society, or poverty, or ignorance, and better systems will fix us. Some say there is no "wrong" at all, only what we happen to dislike. The Bible gives a different answer, and it is harder and more hopeful than any of them. The world is not the way it was made. Something happened. A good world was broken from the inside, by the very creatures God made to care for it.

Genesis 3 is one of the most important chapters ever written. If you understand it, you will understand the rest of the Bible, because the rest of the Bible is God's answer to it. You will understand the news. And you will understand yourself, which is the hardest part. But do not miss what is hidden in the middle of the chapter. In the same breath that God pronounces judgment, he makes a promise. The darkest page in the story holds its first ray of light.

The Word: Offspring

> **Genesis 3:14–15** *"The LORD God said to the serpent, 'Because you have done this, cursed are you above all livestock and above all beasts of the field; on your belly you shall go, and dust you shall eat all the days of your life. I will put enmity between you and the woman, and between your offspring and her offspring; he shall bruise your head, and you shall bruise his heel.'"*

זֶרַע *(zera‘, “offspring”)*

literally “seed”; a person’s descendants, whether a whole line or one child

many	→	one
a whole line of descendants		*a single descendant*
God later promises Abraham, “I will make your offspring as the dust of the earth” (Gen. 13:16). One word for millions.		In 3:15 the war is between two lines, but the victory narrows to one: “*he* shall bruise your head.”

Payoff: The word for “offspring” can mean a whole people or a single child, and Genesis 3:15 uses it both ways in one verse. There will be two families in history, the serpent’s and the woman’s, at war with each other. But the last line focuses on one person from the woman’s line who will take a wound to the heel and give a crushing blow to the head. Jewish translators who put the Old Testament into Greek, centuries before Jesus, used a masculine “he” here even though their word for “seed” was not masculine. They read it as a person. Paul uses the same kind of reasoning about God’s promise to Abraham: “It does not say, ‘And to offsprings,’ referring to many, but referring to one, ‘And to your offspring,’ who is Christ” (Gal. 3:16). Christians have called Genesis 3:15 the “first gospel.” “Gospel” means “good news,” and this is the first good news announced after the fall. The rest of the Bible traces this line of offspring, generation by generation, looking for the one who would crush the serpent’s head.

Part One: “Did God Actually Say?”

> **Genesis 3:1–5** *“Now the serpent was more crafty than any other beast of the field that the LORD God had made. He said to the woman, ‘Did God actually say, “You shall not eat of any tree in the garden”?’ And the woman said to the serpent, ‘We may eat of the fruit of the trees in the garden, but God said, “You shall not eat of the fruit of the tree that is in the midst of the garden, neither shall you touch it, lest you die.”’ But the serpent said to the woman, ‘You will not surely die. For God knows that when you eat of it your eyes will be opened, and you will be like God, knowing good and evil.’”*

Who is this serpent? Genesis does not say, but the last book of the Bible does: “that ancient serpent, who is called the devil and Satan, the deceiver of the whole world” (Rev. 12:9). A real enemy, older than Adam, spoke through a real creature. And notice that he never once says, “Disobey God.” He is too clever for that. Watch how he works, because he still works the same way.

First, he questions God’s word. “Did God actually say…?” He opens with a question, not an argument. He gets the woman thinking about God’s command instead of simply trusting it. And he twists it: “You shall not eat of *any* tree.” God had said the opposite. Every tree but one was a gift. The serpent turns a generous Father into a stingy one.

Second, he denies God's warning. "You will not surely die." This is the first lie in the Bible, and it is still the most popular one. There are no real consequences. God does not mean what he says. You can do this and be fine.

Third, he slanders God's heart. "For God knows that when you eat of it your eyes will be opened, and you will be like God." In other words: God is holding out on you. He is keeping something good from you because he does not want you to be his equal. The serpent was aiming past the fruit at the woman's trust in God's goodness.

Look at the woman's answer, too. She adds to God's word ("neither shall you touch it") and softens his warning ("lest you die" instead of "you shall surely die"). She is already beginning to see God as harsher than he is and his warning as weaker than it is. That is how temptation still works. Before the hand reaches, the heart doubts whether God is good and whether he means what he says.

Part Two: Their Eyes Were Opened

> **Genesis 3:6–7** *"So when the woman saw that the tree was good for food, and that it was a delight to the eyes, and that the tree was to be desired to make one wise, she took of its fruit and ate, and she also gave some to her husband who was with her, and he ate. Then the eyes of both were opened, and they knew that they were naked. And they sewed fig leaves together and made themselves loincloths."*

It happens in one sentence. She saw, she desired, she took, she ate, she gave. And Adam was "with her" (3:6). Nothing suggests he was anywhere else while the serpent talked. He had heard God's command directly (Gen. 2:16–17), before the woman was even made, and he said nothing and then ate. The Shorter Catechism names their sin simply: "The sin whereby our first parents fell from the estate wherein they were created was their eating the forbidden fruit" (WSC 15). It may look small, but it was the creature deciding to be the judge of good and evil instead of trusting the Creator's word. Every sin since has the same root.

The serpent had promised, "your eyes will be opened." And they were. But what they saw was not glory. They saw their own nakedness, and for the first time they were ashamed. Last week's lesson ended with "the man and his wife were both naked and were not ashamed" (2:25). Now they rush to cover themselves. Shame entered the world in a moment, and it has never left. Every one of us knows the instinct: to hide, to cover, to make sure no one sees what we really are.

> **Genesis 3:8–9** *"And they heard the sound of the LORD God walking in the garden in the cool of the day, and the man and his wife hid themselves from the presence of the LORD God among the trees of the garden. But the LORD God called to the man and said to him, 'Where are you?'"*

Before, the sound of God coming near was the best sound in the garden. Now it is terrifying. They hide among the very trees God gave them. And then comes one of the most tender sentences in the Bible. God, who knew exactly where they were, came looking: "Where are you?" The question was a summons out of hiding. Before God asked what they had done, he asked where they were.

Then the blame begins. Adam: "The woman whom you gave to be with me, she gave me fruit of the tree, and I ate" (3:12). He blames his wife, and in the same breath he blames God for giving her to him. Eve: "The serpent deceived me, and I ate" (3:13). Neither one says, "I did it. I am sorry." A few minutes into the fall, the man who spoke the first love poem in Genesis 2 is pointing at his wife. That is what sin does to love.

Part Three: The Curse and the Promise

Now God speaks judgment, and it is important to see how he does it. He curses the serpent: "cursed are you above all livestock" (3:14). He curses the ground: "cursed is the ground because of you" (3:17). Notice where the word "cursed" lands. God never says it directly to the man or the woman. That does not mean they escaped. The ground is cursed "because of you," and the Catechism will tell us that all mankind fell "under his wrath and curse" (WSC 19). In the Bible a curse is the opposite of the blessing God spoke over them in Genesis 1:28: his sentence of judgment, cutting off life and good. But the first "cursed" is aimed at the enemy, and that tells us which way the story is going.



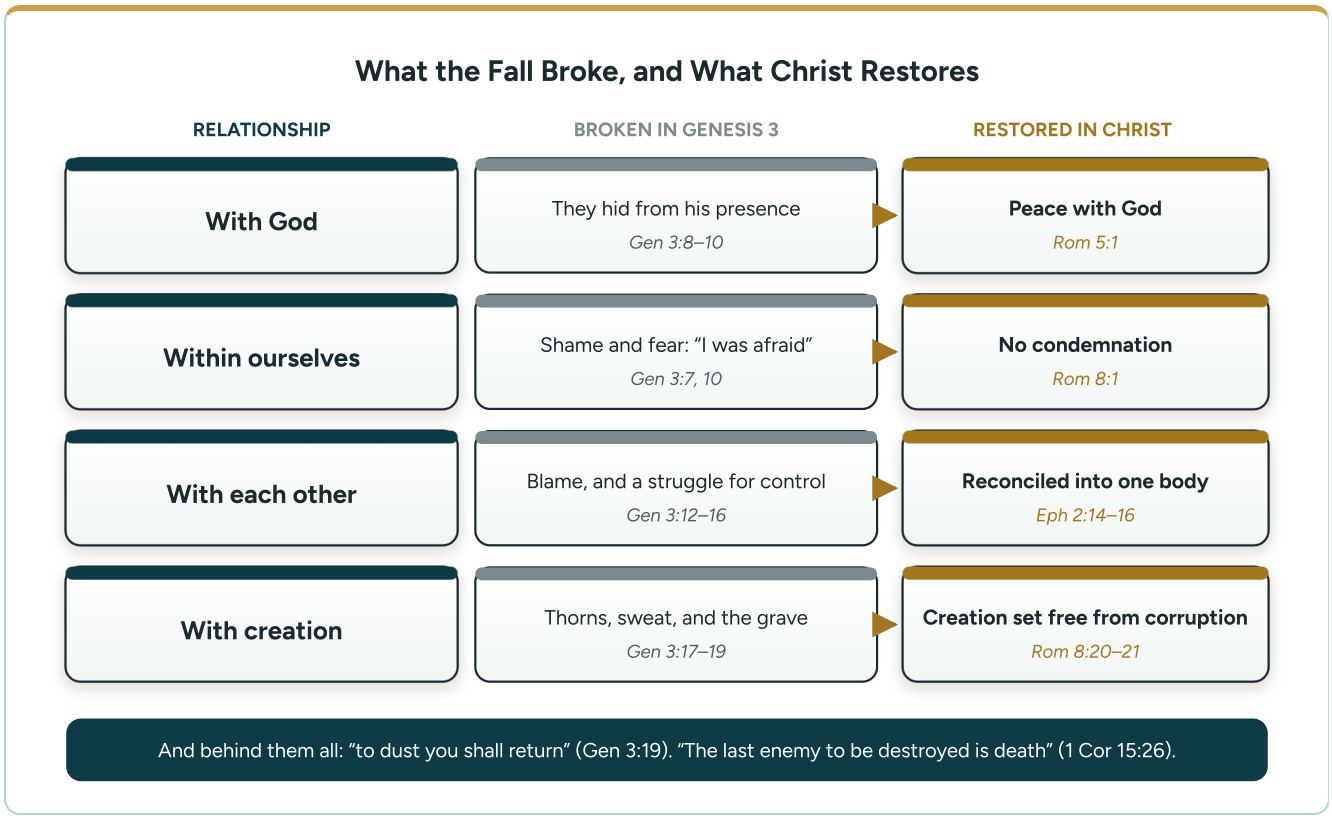
"Thorns and thistles it shall bring forth for you… By the sweat of your face you shall eat bread, till you return to the ground" (Gen. 3:18–19).

To the woman: pain in bearing children, and a marriage that pulls against itself. “Your desire shall be for your husband, and he shall rule over you” (3:16). The partnership of Genesis 2 will become a contest, her will set against his and his leadership turned harsh. The gift of life will come through pain. The gift of marriage will now come with a fight. To the man: the ground will fight him. Thorns and thistles. Sweat. Work, which was a joy in the garden, will now feel like a battle he can never fully win (3:17–19). And at the end of it all: “for you are dust, and to dust you shall return” (3:19). God had warned, “in the day that you eat of it you shall surely die” (2:17). That day they died. Their bodies would now slowly wear out toward the grave, but in the deepest sense they died at once. The Confession says they “became dead in sin” (WCF 6.2), cut off from the life of God and hiding from him in the trees.

Every grief you have ever felt traces back to this chapter. The labor room. The quarrel at the kitchen table. The job that grinds you down. The diagnosis. The grave. That is not how it was meant to be, and the Bible never asks you to pretend it is fine.

But look again at where God puts the promise. Not after the judgment, when things have calmed down. In the middle of it, in the very sentence he speaks to the serpent: “he shall bruise your head, and you shall bruise his heel” (3:15). Before God says a word to Adam and Eve about pain and thorns and dust, he tells the enemy that he is going to lose. A child of the woman will come. He will be wounded. And he will crush the serpent’s head. The first word of judgment Adam and Eve heard was a promise of rescue, spoken over their heads to their enemy.

The Shorter Catechism gives this promise a name. God, “out of his mere good pleasure,” did “enter into a covenant of grace, to deliver them out of the estate of sin and misery, and to bring them into an estate of salvation by a redeemer” (WSC 20). Adam broke the covenant of works. Genesis 3:15 is the first word of another covenant, one that rests on what God will do through the woman’s offspring.



Part Four: Garments of Skins

> **Genesis 3:20–21** *"The man called his wife's name Eve, because she was the mother of all living. And the LORD God made for Adam and for his wife garments of skins and clothed them."*

Two quiet verses, and both are full of grace. First, Adam names his wife Eve, a name that sounds like the Hebrew for "life-giver" and resembles the word for "living," "because she was the mother of all living." God had just said they would die. Adam names his wife Life-giver. It sounds like he believed the promise. A child would come from her, and through that child, life.

Second, God makes clothes for them. Their fig leaves were their own attempt to cover their shame, and fig leaves do not last. So God himself made them garments of skins. Genesis does not explain it, but you cannot have skins without a death. For the first time in the Bible, something died so that sinners could be covered. God provided what their shame needed and they could not make. Hold on to that picture. It is the first thread of the Lamb.



"At the east of the garden of Eden he placed the cherubim and a flaming sword that turned every way to guard the way to the tree of life" (Gen. 3:24).

Then God drove them out of the garden, "lest he reach out his hand and take also of the tree of life and eat, and live forever" (3:22–24). This was judgment. The tree of life was the sign of the life God had promised for obedience, and Adam had thrown that life away. But there was mercy folded inside the judgment. To live forever in a fallen, dying state, with no way back to God, would be a nightmare without end. So the way to the tree of life was closed, and cherubim, mighty angelic guardians, stood at the east of the garden with a flaming sword. The road back to God's presence was shut. Humanity would now live east of Eden, and the whole rest of the Bible is the story of how God would open that road again.

Part Five: In Adam All Die

You might be thinking: that is a sad story about two people a very long time ago. What does it have to do with me? The Bible's answer is: everything. Remember from last week that Adam stood as the head and representative of the whole human race in the covenant of works (God's promise of life to Adam, and in him to us, on condition of perfect obedience). When he fell, we fell with him.

> **Romans 5:12** *"Therefore, just as sin came into the world through one man, and death through sin, and so death spread to all men because all sinned"*

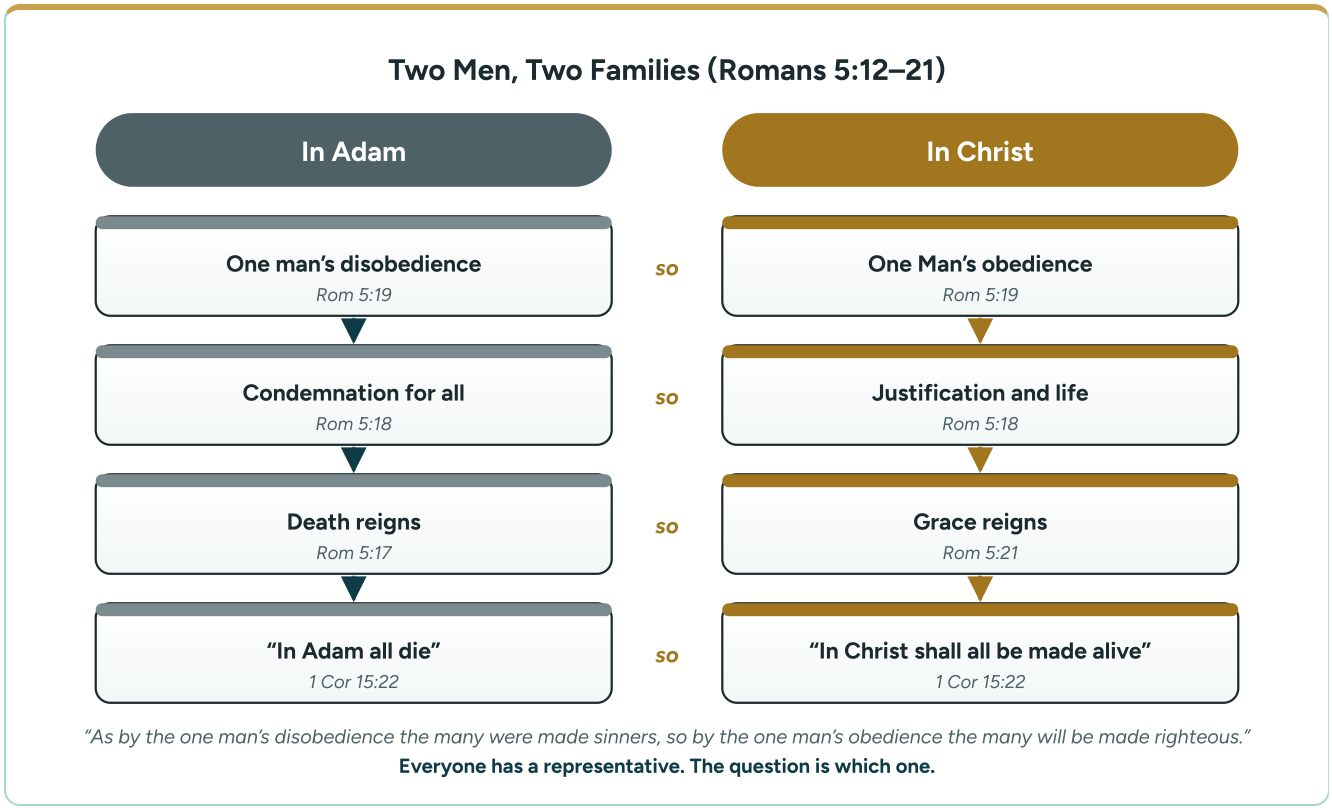
Paul breaks off his sentence there and picks it up again a few verses later. The Shorter Catechism explains it: "The covenant being made with Adam, not only for himself, but for his posterity; all mankind, descending from him by ordinary generation, sinned in him, and fell with him, in his first transgression" (WSC 16). The phrase "by ordinary generation" is there for a reason. There is one human being who did not descend from Adam the ordinary way, and you will meet him in the Turn.

This is what Christians call **original sin**. It means two things. First, we share Adam's guilt, because he acted as our representative. Second, we inherit Adam's corrupted nature. From birth our hearts are turned away from God, and that corruption runs through every part of us: mind, will, desires, and body (WCF 6.2). We cannot turn ourselves back (WCF 6.4). David said, "Behold, I was brought forth in iniquity, and in sin did my mother conceive me" (Ps. 51:5). Paul says that before Christ we were "dead in the trespasses and sins" and "by nature children of wrath, like the rest of mankind" (Eph. 2:1, 3). The Catechism defines sin as "any want of conformity unto, or transgression of, the law of God" (WSC 14). That covers what we fail to do and be, as well as what we do.

The Catechism is honest about where that leaves us. "All mankind by their fall lost communion with God, are under his wrath and curse, and so made liable to all the miseries in this life, to death itself, and to the pains of hell forever" (WSC 19). That is hard to read. It should be. God's wrath is his settled, just opposition to evil, the right response of a holy God to what ruins his world and the people he made. "Liable" means rightly answerable for it. Hell is that just sentence carried out without end, and Jesus himself warned of it plainly (Matt. 10:28). A doctor who will not name the disease cannot treat it. And the Bible names the disease so plainly because it has a cure.

Does it seem unfair that Adam should represent us? Before you decide, look at the very next thing Paul says. The same principle that sank us in Adam is the principle God uses to save us in Christ:

> **Romans 5:18–19** *"Therefore, as one trespass led to condemnation for all men, so one act of righteousness leads to justification and life for all men. For as by the one man's disobedience the many were made sinners, so by the one man's obedience the many will be made righteous."*



Two more things help. Adam was no poor choice. He was made upright, set in a perfect world, given one clear command, and stood with every advantage any of us could ask for. If he fell there, none of us would have done better in his place. And each of us has signed our own name under his choice. Death spread "because all sinned" (Rom. 5:12), and our own sins show that we agree with what he did.

If one man could not act for many, then one Man could not save many. Representation is how we fell, and it is how we are rescued. In Adam, a whole human race was ruined by one man's disobedience. In Christ, a new humanity is made righteous by one Man's obedience. Paul's "all" on each side means all who belong to that head: everyone in Adam by birth, everyone in Christ by faith. "Justification" means God declaring a guilty sinner righteous in his sight because of what that sinner's representative has done (WSC 33). "For as in Adam all die, so also in Christ shall all be made alive" (1 Cor. 15:22).

THREAD WATCH

GOD WITH HIS PEOPLE Humanity is driven out of the garden, and cherubim guard the way back (Gen. 3:24). When God later gives Israel a tabernacle, the curtain that closes off the Most Holy Place, the inner room of his presence, has cherubim woven into it (Ex. 26:31). The way in is still guarded. Solomon's temple hung the same kind of curtain, with cherubim worked on it (2 Chron. 3:14). When Jesus died, "the curtain of the temple was torn in two, from top to bottom" (Matt. 27:51), and the road back to God was opened "through the curtain, that is, through his flesh" (Heb. 10:20).

THE LAMB Adam and Eve tried to cover their shame with fig leaves. God covered them with skins (Gen. 3:21), and something died so that they could be clothed. Genesis does not call this a sacrifice, and no animal could take away sin (Heb. 10:4). But the picture is planted here: when sinners cannot cover themselves, God provides the covering, and it costs a life. Isaiah later gives God's redeemed people this song: "he has clothed me with the garments of salvation; he has covered me with the robe of righteousness" (Isa. 61:10).

The Turn: The Second Adam in a Garden



"And twisting together a crown of thorns, they put it on his head" (Matt. 27:29). The sign of the curse, worn by the King.

"Where are you?" God called that out in the first garden, and he has never stopped calling. Jesus said, "For the Son of Man came to seek and to save the lost" (Luke 19:10). God came looking for Adam. In Jesus, God came looking for you.

Paul calls Jesus "the last Adam" and "the second man" (1 Cor. 15:45, 47). Now watch how the Gospels tell the story of Jesus, and see Genesis 3 running backward. The first Adam was formed from the ground and given God's breath. Jesus was "born of woman" (Gal. 4:4), the woman's offspring of 3:15. He is a true son of Adam through his mother (Luke 3:38), but he was conceived by the Holy Spirit, so he did not come from Adam by ordinary generation and did not fall with him. The first Adam was tempted in a garden full of food and fell. Jesus was tempted in a wilderness after forty days without food, and he stood (Matt.

4:1–11). The first Adam reached for what God had forbidden and said, in effect, "my will be done." On the night before he died, Jesus went into another garden (John 18:1) and prayed, "Father, if you are willing, remove this cup from me. Nevertheless, not my will, but yours, be done" (Luke 22:42).

The ground was cursed with thorns because of Adam. The soldiers twisted those thorns into a crown and pressed it on Jesus' head (Matt. 27:29). Adam was sentenced to die and return to dust. Jesus, who had no sin of his own, went to death in his place. Paul says, "Christ redeemed us from the curse of the law by becoming a curse for us," and he quotes Moses: "Cursed is everyone who is hanged on a tree" (Gal. 3:13). The heel was struck, and in that very act the serpent's head took its death blow. "The reason the Son of God appeared was to destroy the works of the devil" (1 John 3:8). He shared our flesh "that through death he might destroy the one who has the power of death, that is, the devil" (Heb. 2:14). The serpent still thrashes, and Christians still feel his bite. But his defeat is sealed, and Paul promises the end of it: "The God of peace will soon crush Satan under your feet" (Rom. 16:20).

And to a dying thief who turned to him on the next cross, Jesus said, "Truly, I say to you, today you will be with me in paradise" (Luke 23:43). "Paradise" is the word the Greek Old Testament used for the garden of Eden (Gen. 2:8). The road east of Eden, guarded by a flaming sword, was opened for a criminal by a dying King. The Bible's last chapter shows the tree of life again, open to God's people (Rev. 22:2), and says, "No longer will there be anything accursed" (Rev. 22:3).

Genesis 3 leaves you with a question about your own fig leaves. We all sew them: good works, a decent reputation, comparisons with people worse than us, all stitched together to cover what we really are. Fig leaves do not last. God offers a different covering, one he provided at the cost of a death. "For our sake he made him to be sin who knew no sin, so that in him we might become the righteousness of God" (2 Cor. 5:21). Stop hiding in the trees. When God calls, "Where are you?" answer him honestly. Turn from your sin and trust the Offspring of the woman, who was bruised for you and rose again on the third day (1 Cor. 15:3–4). He will clothe you in his own righteousness.

Living It: Six Practices for This Week

1. **Read Genesis 3 twice.** Once straight through. Then a second time, marking every question in the chapter: who asks it, and why.

2. **Name your fig leaves.** Write down one or two ways you try to cover your sin or shame instead of confessing it. Then bring them to God in prayer.

3. **Watch for the three moves.** When you are tempted this week, ask: Am I doubting God's word? Denying the consequences? Suspecting God of holding out on me?

4. **Stop the blame chain.** The next time you are tempted to say "but she" or "but they," say instead, "I did it. I was wrong." To God first, then to the person.

5. **Answer "Where are you?"** Spend ten quiet minutes this week telling God honestly where you are: what you are hiding, what you fear, what you want.

6 **Memorize Genesis 3:15.** “I will put enmity between you and the woman, and between your offspring and her offspring; he shall bruise your head, and you shall bruise his heel.”

Before Lesson 5: *Read Genesis 4, Genesis 6–9, and Genesis 11:1–9. Lesson 5 follows sin as it spreads: a murder, a flood, and a tower.*

For Discussion

1. What explanations for “why the world feels wrong” have you heard? How does Genesis 3 answer the question differently?
2. The serpent questioned God’s word, denied his warning, and slandered his heart. Which of those three do you find most tempting? Why?
3. Why do you think God’s first words after the fall were a question, “Where are you?” What does that tell you about him?
4. Adam blamed Eve and God; Eve blamed the serpent. Where do you see the blame chain in our world, and in your own life?
5. Why does it matter that God placed the promise of 3:15 in the middle of the judgment, before he spoke to Adam and Eve?
6. Read Romans 5:18–19. Why is the idea of a representative both the bad news and the good news?
7. Look at the ways Jesus reverses Genesis 3 (the garden, the thorns, the tree, “paradise”). Which one means the most to you, and why?

Sources & For Further Study

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- For further reading: Derek Kidner, *Genesis* (Tyndale Old Testament Commentaries); Cornelius Plantinga Jr., *Not the Way It’s Supposed to Be: A Breviary of Sin*; John Murray, *The Imputation of Adam’s Sin*.



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